

POTENTIAL FOR PRIVATE PARTICIPATION

The potential for private entrepreneurs has been demonstrated in developed western economies due to the presence of an ecosystem where they have been a major contributor to the space sector. SpaceX and Blue Origin are lead examples in this regard. In comparison, India has started encouraging private participation only in the past two years. "What we are trying to do is to create an ecosystem or environment that will allow start-ups or even existing big business houses to come to the space sector and invest and create the business opportunity, which was previously absent," says S. Somanath, Chairperson of ISRO, who is also Secretary, Department of Space. "There is business potential in various fields like launch vehicles, spacecraft and other applications to create a framework on which this concept can grow."

Now, who would know that better than former ISRO employees and now Skyroot Aerospace Co-founders, Pawan Kumar Chandana, 31, and Naga Bharat Daka, 32, who have been in the news for their Vikram series of launch

vehicles. Chandana, a graduate in mechanical engineering from IIT Kharagpur, and Daka, a graduate in electronics from IIT Madras, who were batchmates at the space agency's Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre (VSSC) in Thiruvananthapuram, took a leap of faith when they decided to launch their own company in 2018. Incidentally, VSSC also happens to be ISRO's prime facility for the design and development of launch vehicle technology.

"Things moved faster than we had expected. The government opened the sector during the pandemic period in 2020, and we became

AGNIKUL COSMOS, CHENNAI

Founded 2017

Founders (L to R) Moin S.P.M., Srinath Ravichandran

Employees 85

Product Development of small-lift mobile launch systems such as Agnibaan to place 100-kg payloads into a 700-km orbit

Funding The company has raised \$15 million in funding to date



PHOTO BY SUMANTH KUMAR